

3. Choose Remove from list (or similar).

If your Start supports hiding Recommended entirely, use that option.

5) Make Start stop feeling like ads

Windows sometimes pushes “tips” and “suggestions” in Start and notifications. Your goal is to reduce the “helpfulness” that behaves like nagging.

Step-by-step: Reduce suggestions in Start + notifications

A) Start settings

1. Settings → Personalization → Start.
2. Turn off anything that mentions tips / suggestions / recommendations.

B) Notifications

1. Settings → System → Notifications.
 2. Turn off prompts that offer “suggestions” or “tips” while using Windows (wording varies by build).
- This doesn’t break Windows. It just makes it quieter.

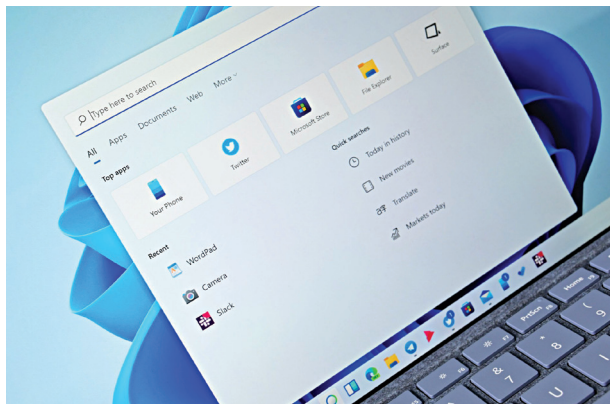
6) Pin folders you actually open

Pinned apps are only half the Start story. The other half is fast access to folders – especially Downloads and Documents for students and office workers.

Microsoft explicitly supports choosing which folders appear next to the power button area in Start.

Step-by-step: Add useful folders to Start

1. Settings → Personalization → Start.
2. Select Folders (or “Choose which folders appear on Start”).
3. Turn on what you need:
 - Downloads (almost always worth it)
 - Documents
 - Pictures/Videos (if you create content)
 - Network/Personal folder (if you use them)



HIGH-IMPACT START SETUPS

Setup A: Student / Exam mode

- **Start pins (first 2 rows):** Browser, File Explorer, PDF reader, Word, PowerPoint, Excel, Calculator, Snipping Tool, OneNote/Notion, Zoom/Meet.
- **Folders:** Downloads, Documents.
- **Taskbar:** Browser, File Explorer, PDF reader, Zoom/Teams.

Setup B: Office / WFH mode

- **Start pins:** Browser, File Explorer, Outlook/mail, Teams, Excel, Word, VPN client, password manager, Snipping Tool, Settings.
- **Folders:** Downloads, Documents, Personal folder (if you use it).
- **Taskbar:** Browser, File Explorer, Teams, Outlook/mail, Excel.
- **Consistency wins:** keep the same flows every day.

4. Open Start and check near the power area – your folder shortcuts should appear.

7) Start Search: Use it

The fastest Start menu is the one you barely look at. Windows Search is the real power feature – when you use it correctly.

The habit:

- Press Windows key
- Type 3–6 letters
- Hit Enter

What to search for:

- “bluetooth” (Bluetooth settings)
- “storage” (Storage settings)
- “device manager” (Device Manager)
- “terminal” (Windows Terminal)
- “snip” (Snipping Tool)
- “power” (power settings)

Step-by-step: Keep search indexing sane (so search stays fast)

Search relies on indexing. Microsoft’s guidance for managing search/indexing is built into Settings under Privacy & security.

1. Settings → Privacy & security → Search / Searching Windows.
2. Choose a balanced “find my files” / indexing mode if offered.
3. Use Customize search locations to avoid indexing massive folders you don’t need (like a video dump).